

Just Full of Surprises

Flying private made these repeated trips to Australia more bearable, but it did not make them fun. Once we all got over our jet lag, though, another new normal took hold at RSI.

The rookies went back to being coached by Tiz and Steph, though I made sure to keep a close eye on things and I liked what I saw. No longer strangers in a strange land, the younger fighters seemed to have finally gotten comfortable with their surroundings. More precisely, they were more comfortable with the teammates they shared those surroundings with. I noticed they seemed to get occasional visits from the likes of Emily, J-Law and the ever-intimidating Emma. None sought to get involved in anything. They just seemed to be checking in. Making efforts to be inclusive, and it was clear from the way the young trio were opening up that it was working.

Danni, meanwhile, tried to go back to her usual training inasmuch as her teammates would allow it. Each day, in the space between workouts and sparring with Mandy, she would be visited by one of her teammates. For a few days, it was Emma. Then came Emily. Then Jules. Catherine Bell even got involved, which was something new. Like Danni, Cat prefers to be in the background, but I guess even she felt the need to be a part of this. Maybe she wanted to pay Danni back, like so many of the others did. Or maybe she just thought it would be fun. It was easy to see how that could happen. After all, based on the big smiles that crossed her face each day, Danni was sure enjoying herself. In fact, I suspected she knew exactly what her teammates were up to, but she was having too much fun to try and put a stop to it.

Best of all, the women were careful to leave enough in Danni's tank to allow our late-night sparring sessions to continue. Which was good because I was more committed than ever.

Despite the fact that she was back to looking every bit the champion we all knew her to be, I refused to let things coast. I continued to push myself, making sure I could give her my best at all times. That meant continuing to spend my days getting beat up by the finest fighters RSI had to offer. These women were seasoned veterans with hundreds of fights worth of experience between them. They had no shortage of tricks up their sleeve, making every day a painful but productive adventure. And then, somewhere in the process of learning to not get myself killed, an idea started to take shape.

Aside from maybe Mandy, no one at RSI knows Danni's game the way I do. That makes it easier for me to make her work for every inch, but there's a catch. She knows my tendencies, too. So, I can push her but I can't surprise her. But...

What if Danni started to train directly with these women? Not just the casual sparring they were doing now, but full-on training sessions. Each of them had a different style and a different set of favored techniques. Surely, they could force Danni to up her game in ways that I couldn't.

The more I thought about the idea, the more I fell in love with it. Then I mentioned it to Steph, who shot me down in short order.

I've discovered that Steph has two basic tones of voice. Most of the time, she speaks without inflection. Like she was reading you her grocery list. But, when she's angry, her words come out low and dark with sort of a growling sound attached to them. It's a tone that puts ice in your veins and reverberates inside your skull, causing your brain to scream out, DANGER! DANGER!

When that happens, you should listen because your brain is right.

Luckily she was giving me flat and emotionless now. Like she was patiently explaining reality to the small of mind.

"Having these fighters rotate through sparring with you is one thing, but now you want to turn the entire stable into Danni's personal training staff?" she asked.

"I hadn't really thought of it like that."

"Did you think about the way it would upset everyone else's training schedule?"

"Well, no..."

"How about the fact that working with a dozen people at once is a stupid way to train?"

"I guess..."

"Oh, and then there's the part where Danni would never go for it, anyway."

"Steph?"

"Yeah?"

"You can stop now."

"You sure? Cause I got more."

"I'm good. Thanks."

She was right, of course. My obsession with Danni was showing through again. My plan might work great for her, but it would disrupt everyone else.

So maybe it wasn't my greatest idea. That didn't mean I was just going to give up. I had solved a lot of problems in my life by sticking my thick skull in harm's way, and that seemed to be the perfect answer here, as well.

Since I didn't have the arsenal I needed to surprise Danni now, I would have to get myself some new weapons. The rotation schedule was already in place. We would simply change the goal a bit. If each fighter

could just show me one thing... reveal one technique from her bag of tricks... that would give me what I needed.

So, that's how I found myself gloved up and standing across the cage from Emily, once again.

"You want me to do what?" she asked.

"I want you to teach me your go-to move."

"What are you talking about? I don't have a go-to move."

I cocked my head and gave her a doubtful look.

"Oh, I think you do," I said.

The women of RSI represent an interesting and varied mix of fight styles, and Emily is our resident kickboxer. While all of our fighters have trained in the Muay Thai style, Em is the one who's taken to it like a duck to water. All flying limbs and sharp elbows, there is no telling what hell she might unleash on an opponent next. But there is no mystery when it comes to her put-away move. It's that patented high kick of hers. The one she used three and a half years ago to finally stop Irina Sheik and grab hold of the ESL lightweight title. That moment was the beginning of a trend that was now known far and wide by fighters and fans alike.

"You want me to kick you in the head?" she asked.

"Noooo," I said - shaking my head emphatically. "I want me to show me how you do it."

"Oh," she said disappointedly.

This was getting a little ridiculous.

"Well," she began, "it's really nothing special."

Indeed, as impressive as the result often was, the kick itself was kind of routine. The secret was in the different ways she could get to it. Sometimes, she would just unleash it by itself. Other times, she would throw it in a combination. And she could throw it at any point in a sequence, too. Off the jab. After the cross. I once saw her take down an opponent by launching it after a knee strike... with the same leg. After feinting high, she had closed inside and driven her right knee into her opponent's midsection. Then, she jumped back, almost as if she were recoiling after touching something hot. Confused, her opponent had naturally pressed after her, only to realize too late that the kick was coming.

The slow-motion replay of the sequence looks like something out of a Looney Tunes episode. Emily hopping back like Yosemite Sam yelling, "My biscuits are burning!" Suddenly, she's balanced and in-control - turning like a dancer as her right foot comes off the floor, just as an eager and oblivious Selena Gomez gamely advances right into the line of fire. There's a brief moment - a fleeting, oh shit second right

before impact - where recognition registers on Gomez's face. Then her facial features become rubbery and comically contorted from the force of Em's foot driving into her head like a hammer hitting a nail.

In real time, Selena fell to the canvas before Emily got both feet back on the ground. In slow-motion, an eternity passes before Gomez's limp, unconscious form finally drops out of the bottom of the frame.

Anyway... that's what the little impromptu session became about. Timing and technique. She talked about balance. Being able to set my stance quickly so I could smoothly roll into the kick. She talked strategy. How to work the kick in, and how to know when to throw it. The key, she told me, was in making sure your opponent was where you wanted her, mentally-speaking. To work other techniques and strategies repeatedly to set her expectations, then break the rhythm by suddenly launching the kick. She warned me of the dangers involved, too. That missing big would leave an enormous hole in my defense.

It would occur to me later that, despite the fact that all of the women had been awesome with me, none had been able to dissect and explain every nuance the way Emily had.

It was sad, then, that I wasn't able to put what I'd learned to more effective use.

There is a suddenness Emily has when she makes her move that I simply wasn't able to match. When she does it - even if you see it coming - it's too late to do anything more than watch yourself get kicked in the face. So, I think I did a decent job. I was patient as I worked to set the move up, and I rolled into it as smoothly as I could. But I didn't have the practice Em has had, and the explosiveness just wasn't there. Danni was definitely surprised, but she was able to react quickly enough, leaning away and whipping her head out of the path of my foot.

She retreated a step, then set her stance and peered at me over the top of her guard with a what the hell was that? look on her face.

I tried the move twice more as the session wound down without success. By the time it was over, Danni knew I was up to something.

"Got some new moves in the repertoire," she observed as we towed off.

"You bet your ass," I smiled. "Keep your eyes open, kid."

Day two brought me Daniela Hantuchova and the spinning backfist from hell.

Day three was Britney Spears, who taught me a few new combination ideas that actually worked to great effect on the lovely Ms. Harris.

Day four brought me Emma Watson... who taught me how to get the shit beat out of me in a big hurry.

Emma's strength is not a particular move or technique. Her thing is unpredictability. Not that long ago, she'd been having a lot of trouble handling the size difference between she and Kristen Stewart. I thought she was being a little hard on herself, considering that Kristen is two weight classes heavier, but that fact

was of little consolation to Emma. And, unfortunately, the two kept finding themselves in the cage together. The appeal of seeing Hermione Granger square off with Bella Swan was just too tempting, and fan voting consistently brought she and Kristen together at the open-weight Open Fight Night event. No matter how many times the two met, the novelty just wouldn't wear off... despite the fact that Hermione kept getting her ass kicked.

Though she was quiet about it, the situation had Em royally pissed. When the rest of us found out, a team consisting of Tiffany, Steph, Danni and myself came together to help her solve the problem. It was Steph who impressed upon Emma the value of going against the grain. To work elements into her game that she wasn't necessarily great at and to do things her opponent probably wouldn't expect. Not only did it work on Kristen, but it stuck. Emma's expanded tool chest now includes an impressive clinch game and a variety of ground techniques to go with her terrifying striking skills. More importantly, she has gotten very good at popping up in places her opponent doesn't expect her to be. She advances at times when the basics dictate she should retreat. Her striking ability is best utilized from distance, but she's not afraid to bully her way inside. Often, she stays there longer than she should, waiting until her opponent forces her out rather than scoring some points and retreating back to where she's most effective.

Much of this would seem counterintuitive. Effort was being wasted on techniques she's not that great at instead of focusing her strategy on using her strengths. But Emma enjoys a speed and stamina advantage over most of her opponents that let's her get away with it. And, having now been on the receiving end, I can tell you that it sucks. By frequently doing things I didn't expect, she made it almost impossible for me to recuperate after an exchange. Within minutes, I was worn out. Once that happened, she basically stayed outside and picked me apart.

All in all, she didn't seem nearly as interested in teaching me anything as she was in entertaining herself. She was, however, the one to give my daily training sessions a name.

"You want me to show you something?" she asked when I first approached her.

Then she calmly ascended the steps that led into the cage beside her, pushed open the door and said, "Step into my classroom."

From that day forward, the women collectively referred to each of my little visits as the 'Show Me Something' Stop of the Day.

By the way, I'm working on some techniques to nullify little Ms. Emma's new fearlessness in the cage. I've been reviewing video and noting her tendencies. Once I get it all down, I'm going to return to the classroom and school the teacher. You can take that to the bank.

Anyway... it didn't take long for Danni to figure out where my new moves were coming from, and I think she found the idea of me being tortured by the champion du jour quite amusing. The fighters generally got a good laugh out of it, too. I didn't see what the hell was so funny, but, overall, I didn't care. As far as I was concerned, it was all worth it.

I did my best to have at least one surprise ready for Danni each time we sparred, and she seemed to enjoy the challenge of it. Each day, she would be alert for whatever I had in store. Sometimes she would catch it, and sometimes not. But just being able to keep her vigilant was a victory all on it's own.

Of course, I also should have realized she was going to get me back eventually, and the bombshell she came up with made everything I'd done seem trivial by comparison.

To her credit, she was patient... waiting until the end of yet another grueling session before she sprung it on me. We were both pretty well spent, grappling and leaning into each other for support as we were fighting for position. Then, she suddenly seemed to find a second wind. She pulled away and came up punching. I did a good job of defending myself, but she just kept coming... forcing me to retreat to stay out of harms way. Sensing the fence was coming, I slid left and escaped before she could cut me off. But when she turned to square up with me again, a sinister smile creased her lips.

In hindsight, that should have been a clue.

We closed the distance on each other, and Danni snapped out her jab, then pivoted into a wicked cross. It was the textbook one, two. I'd seen it thousands of times... which is why it was so surprising that both punches landed as if I'd been asleep. The jab set me up, and the cross hit home like I was some sort of human punching dummy.

Even before I hit the canvas, instinct told me something very strange had just occurred.

I sat up and let my head fall into my hands, trying to get my bearings. After a moment or two, I looked up at her.

"What the fuck just happened?" I asked.

The only response I got was that the smile got bigger. Challenging me to figure it out for myself.

I sat and thought about it for a minute, replaying the sequence of events in my mind. I had been ready for the jab. My guard was set and I was expecting it, but the blow had hit me anyway. It seemed to materialize out of nowhere and slammed into...

My mouth fell open as the realization hit me.

Danni's jab had hit me on the left side of my head, followed by the cross from my right.

And that was all wrong.

"No fucking way," I breathed.

"What?" she said with a heaping helping of fake innocence.

"You went Southpaw!"

She nodded as the smile brightened to full wattage.

"You picked that up pretty quick," she said. "Steph would be impressed."

As a right-handed fighter, Danni uses what is known as the orthodox stance. Left foot forward, right foot back. Jab with the left hand. Cross with the right. And so on.

I had stood in front of her with an expectation of what was coming, and I was ready for it. Then, everything she threw came at me from the opposite direction.

In other words, the right-handed Danni had suddenly started fighting left-handed... switching to what's known as the Southpaw stance.

"How did you do that?"

She shrugged.

"It's just something I've been fooling around with on the bag. Steph had me try it a few times to strengthen my off hand. I started getting decent at it. Then I got the idea to spring it on you."

"I've never even heard of this," I marveled.

"Don't be stupid," she said. "People have done it in the ring."

"Like who?"

"I don't know names. I just know it's been done."

I sat and thought about it a little more. It doesn't matter what stance your opponent uses. Experience teaches you how to deal with each. Once you know what you're up against, you can be ready. But an opponent that could switch back and forth? How do you train for that?

"You need to use this," I said.

"For real?" she scoffed. "Not a chance! It was a little trick, that's all. I'm no where near good enough to use it in a fight. I'd look like an idiot."

"You were good enough to knock me on my ass."

Another shrug.

"That's really not that hard."

"Ha-ha," I said dryly. "I'm serious."

"So am I. I'm not doing it."

"What did Steph say?"

"Nothing because we didn't talk about it," she said. "What are you not getting about this?"

"I'm not getting why you wouldn't use a technique that no one is going to see coming!"

"Because it's a gimmick! That's all!"

"You just said yourself that others have done it!"

"Yeah. People who have trained themselves to be able to do it!"

"So... TRAIN!"

She took a deep breath. Like she was winding up to really let me have it. Then she seemed to change her mind, choosing instead to let the air out slowly.

I jumped in while I had the chance.

"I'm right about this, Danni," I said in a quieter tone. "Those weren't just chippy shots you hit me with. You have enough power to do damage, and it will be that much more effective because it's confusing. I get what you're saying about it not being ready for prime time, but we can work on it. At least try, and see what comes of it. Don't give up on it before you even know how good you can get."

She looked annoyed, but I could tell she was thinking it over.

"We'll do it here," I continued. "Just you and me. No one else needs to know until we see if it's going to be worthwhile."

She shook her head slowly.

"This was just supposed to be a joke."

"Well, the joke's on you because I'm not going to let it go."

She gave a sigh to go with a bit more head shaking.

"You're a pain in my ass."

"Damn right, I am."

